



Innate

Seattle Construction Cost Guide [2026 Edition]

January 2026

Introduction

Building and remodeling in the Greater Seattle area varies widely in cost depending on scope, quality, and site complexity — whether you’re considering a kitchen or bathroom remodel, a whole-home renovation, an addition, an ADU, or a custom home.

This guide outlines typical cost ranges for the most common residential projects and groups them into three tiers: Mid-range, High-End, and Luxury. We also highlight the eight key factors that most often drive construction costs higher in Seattle.

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I'm writing this guide because one of the most common points of confusion — and sometimes frustration — for homeowners in Seattle is the cost of construction, and in particular the role and cost of a general contractor. Before explaining why, I want to briefly explain who this is coming from.

I graduated from architecture school, worked closely for several years with a solo practicing architect, then spent a number of years working for a large general contractor in the Seattle area before starting my own design-build company. Over the last 10 years, I've been directly involved in the design, documentation, permitting, construction, or delivery of over 500 residential projects. I've also estimated thousands of residential projects and reviewed thousands of estimates from other builders, competitors, and peers. I've seen projects that went exceptionally well and projects that went sideways.

I've seen what works, what fails, and what creates pain points for clients. At this point, I've encountered almost every major issue that shows up in residential construction, and I understand both the technical and financial implications of them.

In writing this, I hope to correct some of the common misconceptions about the cost of construction and explain why building in Seattle costs what it does. My hope is that after reading this, you will feel more informed and confident as you move forward with your next construction project.

8 COMMON FACTORS THAT DRIVE HIGH CONSTRUCTION PRICES



The Role of a General Contractor



A General Contractor isn't paid to "pass through invoices." They're paid to manage complexity. That includes vetting and coordinating dozens of trades, sequencing hundreds of interdependent tasks months ahead of time, carrying financial and legal risk, and taking responsibility for safety, code compliance, schedule, and outcome. **A GC isn't just managing subs — they're managing risk, time, money, and consequences.**

Labor & Materials



Labor and materials are fundamentally more expensive than they used to be. Construction costs have permanently increased due to labor shortages, inflation, supply chain disruption, tariffs, deportations and demographic shifts in the trades. In Seattle, general labor often costs ~\$60/hr, skilled trades ~\$80–\$100/hr, and licensed specialists \$120+/hr. Material costs remain elevated due to tariffs, shipping, currency effects, and long lead times — adding both cost and schedule risk.

Seattle Terrain



Seattle's steep terrain, dense neighborhoods, seismic requirements, long wet seasons, and older housing stock make construction inherently more complex. These conditions require more excavation, engineering, moisture control, inspections, coordination, and labor time — even for modest projects. This complexity is unavoidable and directly impacts cost.



Design and Architectural Fees



In Seattle, architectural design typically ranges from \$8–\$15 per square foot or 5–15% of construction cost, depending on complexity and customization. Interior design often falls around \$7–\$9 per square foot, with engineering adding another 1–2%. **Overall, architecture, interior design and engineering commonly account for 10–20% of construction cost (depending on how many of those service are required) — and directly influence build quality, coordination, and long-term performance.**

Different Firms Operate in Different Markets



The architect and general contractor you choose largely determine the cost and complexity of your project. A highly sought-after architect designing bespoke details and complex structures will produce a design that is significantly more expensive to build and requires a GC experienced in executing that level of work. A simpler, more utilitarian design can be built by a wider range of contractors at a lower cost. Neither is right or wrong. **The key is understanding which market you're engaging and aligning the company to the outcome you want.**

Sales Tax



Including local sales tax is crucial for a comprehensive budget. In King County, the sales tax ranges from 8.7% to 10.35%, significantly impacting the overall project budget. Many homeowners tend to look past this consideration and many GCs don't include this on their estimate because it isn't a direct labor or material cost.



Financing Costs

Financing costs vary widely and should be carefully considered in the overall budget planning. We're not licensed financial advisors, and this guide isn't intended as financial advice. We recommend speaking with your financial advisor, lender, or other trusted financial professional to determine the right financing approach for your situation.



Permits, Fees, and Infrastructure

In Puget Sound, permitting and infrastructure costs vary widely by jurisdiction and site conditions. For a typical single-family project, building permits often range from \$35,000–\$60,000, with impact and utility connection fees adding \$10,000–\$20,000 or more. Some cities impose additional square-footage-based fees, which can significantly increase costs.

We believe addressing these points will provide our clients with a realistic and comprehensive understanding of what to expect when embarking on new construction projects in the Greater Seattle area. In our experience, an educated and realistic client leads to a smoother construction project.





Mid-range:



Mid-Grade: Averaging around **\$400 per square foot**, mid-grade custom homes are designed with quality, durability, and cost-efficiency in mind. They typically include standard finishes, off-the-shelf fixtures, and moderate architectural details.

High-end:



With an average cost **between \$450 and \$600 per square foot**, high-grade homes offer higher-end finishes, custom architectural features, and more personalized design options, along with premium construction materials.

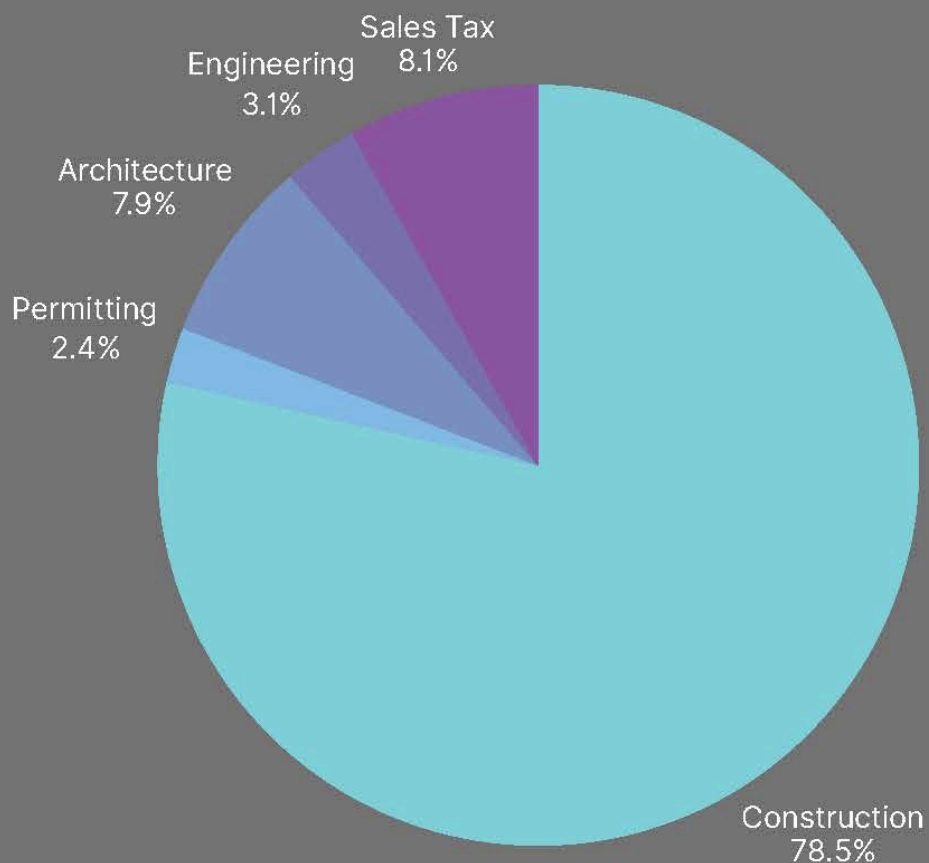
Luxury Homes:



Ranging from **\$600 to \$1,000 per square foot**, luxury custom homes are built with no expense spared. These homes feature top-of-the-line materials, bespoke design and architectural services, advanced technology integration, and unique amenities tailored to the homeowner's exact specifications.

New Construction Cost Graph

This framework provides a strategic financial preview to inform the initiation of your investment. The following diagram illustrates the typical allocation of capital across major project costs. Though every project is different, this visual offers insight into where investment capital is generally allocated.



Source: Christensen Architects "Project Budgeting - New Homes 2026"

ROUGH ORDER OF MAGNITUDE COSTS FOR NEW CONSTRUCTION PROJECTS

Proximity to amenities, schools, transportation, and views continue to drive land values — which is why we recommend exploring the “move” option early with a real estate agent familiar with the local market. Many families come to us facing the same challenge: their family has grown, but their house hasn’t. As a result, most clients find themselves weighing four options:

1. Do nothing.

Stay in an overcrowded, outdated home that no longer functions for a growing family.

2. Build an addition or DADU.

A common way to gain space while staying put.

3. Tear down and rebuild.

A clean-slate approach that allows you to design exactly what you want on your existing lot.

4. Move.

This often means purchasing an older home for teardown rather than buying raw land, since undeveloped lots in prime neighborhoods are scarce.

At Innate, we're very selective about who we refer our clients to — and Andreina Ramirez is one of the few real estate agents we confidently recommend. She's a strong negotiator, an excellent communicator, and someone who genuinely cares about helping people make the right decision — not just a fast one.

Andreina works throughout the Central Puget Sound, from the West Sound through Seattle, Bellevue, and surrounding cities, with a current focus on the Seattle market. She takes the trust placed in her seriously and has a reputation for guiding clients through a smooth, well-managed process from showings to closing.

"Buying or selling a home is a big decision, and I'm here to make sure you feel supported, informed, and confident throughout the process. As a Washington native, I combine deep local insight with a thoughtful, low-pressure approach so you can make the right move with clarity."

Andreina Ramirez

Real Estate Agent,
Keller Williams



Construction Pricing Models:

Fixed-Fee Vs Cost-Plus

There are two common ways construction projects are priced: **fixed-fee** and **cost-plus** — and each works best in different situations.



Fixed-fee agreements are most appropriate when the scope of work is **clearly defined, well understood, and unlikely to change**. This is often the case for straightforward projects like a well-scoped bathroom remodel or a simple interior renovations. In a fixed-fee model, we agree on a defined scope and a set price up front. As long as the project stays within that scope, **you won't be charged more** — unless unexpected challenges arise. In that sense, the risk of overruns sits primarily with us.



Cost-plus agreements are better suited for complex projects where there are unknowns, evolving design decisions, or **conditions that can't be fully seen or predicted at the start** — such as additions, major remodels, or projects involving older homes, structural changes, or difficult sites. In this model, the project is allowed to evolve. We address issues as they're uncovered, adapt as needed, and keep the work moving — with costs tracking the real work being done.



BATHROOM REMODEL

AVERAGE COST FOR TYPICAL BATHROOM REMODEL PROJECTS IN THE GREATER SEATTLE AREA

8x5 Bathroom (Midrange)



A **8x5 midrange bathroom remodel averages around \$36,146** and prioritizes durability and cost efficiency. Typical scope includes ceramic tile flooring, a standard tub/shower with tiled surround, a solid-surface or cultured vanity with integrated sink, standard chrome fixtures, a recessed medicine cabinet, and updated general and task lighting. Finishes are generally off-the-shelf with moderate detailing.

Master Bathroom (High-End)



An **upscale master bathroom remodel averages around \$73,750** and often includes expanding or reconfiguring the space. Common features include large-format tile flooring, a dedicated tiled shower with frameless glass, upgraded fixtures, a soaking or freestanding tub, custom or semi-custom vanity with stone countertop and a general higher level of architectural detail.

Bathroom Addition (Within Existing Footprint)



A **8x5 bathroom addition averages \$52,050** reflecting added design, framing and utility work. Scope typically includes new plumbing, connection to sewer and electrical work, ceramic tile flooring, a standard tub/shower or tiled shower, a vanity with integrated sink, standard fixtures, and general and task lighting. **An more upscale master bathroom addition averages \$82,218** in the Seattle area.

Source: 2026 Cost vs. Value Report (Zonda Media)



KITCHEN REMODEL

AVERAGE COST FOR TYPICAL KITCHEN REMODEL PROJECTS IN THE GREATER SEATTLE AREA

Minor Kitchen Remodel (Midrange)



A **minor midrange kitchen remodel typically costs around \$47,271** and focuses on refreshing a dated but functional kitchen while keeping the existing layout. Scope usually includes refacing or painting existing cabinet boxes with new Shaker-style doors and hardware, installing a basic sink and faucet, replacing countertops and backsplash, updating appliances as needed, refreshing paint and trim, and installing new LVP or resilient flooring.

Major Kitchen Remodel (Midrange)



A **midrange major kitchen remodel averages around \$95,542** and involves updating an outdated kitchen with a more functional layout and upgraded finishes. Typical scope includes semi-custom cabinetry, a small island, natural stone or laminate countertops, a stainless double-bowl sink with standard faucet, updated ventilation, energy-efficient appliances, custom lighting, new resilient flooring, and fully refinished walls, trim, and ceilings.

Major Kitchen Remodel (High-End)



A **high-end major kitchen remodel averages around \$188,401** and delivers a fully customized space with premium materials and appliances. Scope often includes custom cabinetry with built-in storage, stone countertops with tile backsplash, an undermount sink with designer faucet and filtration, cabinet-front appliances, a commercial-style range and hood, wall oven, undercabinet lighting, and tile or wood-look flooring.

Source: 2026 Cost vs. Value Report (Zonda Media)



ADDITION

AVERAGE COST FOR TYPICAL ADDITION
PROJECTS IN THE GREATER SEATTLE AREA

Primary Suite Addition (Midrange)



A midrange primary suite addition typically costs around **\$219,378** and adds a new bedroom and bathroom with standard finishes. Scope commonly includes a carpeted bedroom, walk-in closet, ceramic tile bathroom flooring, a separate tiled shower and freestanding tub, a double vanity with solid-surface countertop, painted finishes throughout, and general and task lighting. All the necessary new electrical, plumbing and HVAC work included.

Major Addition + Remodel (Midrange)



A major addition with partial remodel averages around **\$450,560** and combines a new primary suite with targeted upgrades to existing living spaces. Scope typically includes a spacious bedroom with in-floor heating and soundproofing, custom millwork and built-ins, French doors, fireplace, large walk-in closet, and a high-end bathroom with dual shower, freestanding tub, and frameless glass. Projects at this level often also include a kitchen remodel and selective updates to adjacent interior areas for better flow and finish continuity.

Major Addition + Complete Remodel (incl exterior)



A major addition paired with a complete home remodel typically starts around **\$750,000+** and represents a full transformation of the home. Scope commonly includes an addition, full interior reconfiguration, new kitchens and bathrooms, updated mechanical systems, exterior improvements, and code-compliant fire, sound, and energy upgrades. Final costs vary widely based on home size, site conditions, and finish level.

Source: 2026 Cost vs. Value Report (Zonda Media)



ADU

AVERAGE COST FOR TYPICAL ADU PROJECTS
IN THE GREATER SEATTLE AREA

500 SF DADU / ADU



A 500 SF ADU is a compact, fully independent dwelling suited for rental or guest use, with typical mid-range projects averaging around **\$600 per square foot** (approximately \$300,000 total) and higher-end builds starting at \$600 per square foot (approximately \$300,000), depending on finish level, material quality, and architectural detailing.

750 SF DADU / ADU



A 750 SF ADU commonly includes one or two small bedrooms, one or two bathrooms, defined living and dining areas, a full kitchen, and often a dedicated laundry and storage. Mid-range projects typically fall around **\$500 per square foot** (approximately \$375,000 total) and higher-end builds range from \$600 per square foot (approximately \$450,000), reflecting upgraded kitchens, bathrooms, and interior finishes.

1,000 SF DADU / ADU



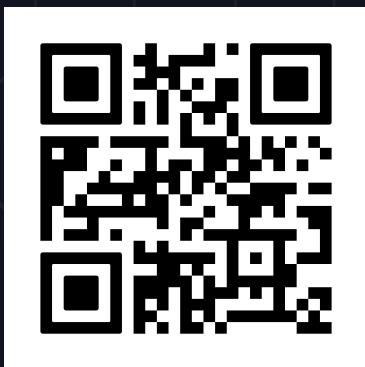
A 1,000 SF ADU functions as a small standalone home and often includes a primary bedroom, a guest bedroom, one or two bathrooms, a full kitchen, defined living and dining areas, and a dedicated laundry. Mid-range projects typically cost **\$450 per square foot** and higher-end builds range from \$500–\$600 per square foot depending on complexity, site conditions, and level of customization.

Source: 2026 Cost vs. Value Report (Zonda Media)

Success is a collection of problems solved.

- I. M. Pei

*So book your remodel today and let us
solve the problem that is your project!*



↙ SCAN CODE TO START TODAY!

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